



The hidden costs of gentrification: Displacement in central London

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Received February 2000; Accepted October 2000

Abstract. This paper explores the process of displacement from gentrification in three areas in central London. Taking as its focus the recent stress in policy documents on the need for mixed communities, the paper argues that extensive gentrification in the case study areas threatens the sustainability of community networks and of those services which excluded groups rely on. Drawing on disparate sources of data, the paper pieces together a picture of the scale and experience of displacement. It argues that there is a need to rethink the *laissez faire* policy toward neighbourhoods and the desirability with which many view influxes of wealthy households into previously poor areas.

Key words: displacement, eviction, gentrification, London, neighbourhoods

1. Introduction

This paper is about the social changes that have been going on in central London in recent years. The focus is on the increasing numbers of professionals moving to the central boroughs of London. Boroughs are the main administrative units of local government in London. These political entities are similar to local authorities in non-metropolitan areas of Britain. London's population of seven million is divided into thirty-three boroughs, including the City of London.

Gentrification has commonly been referred to as “the rehabilitation of working-class and derelict housing and the consequent transformation of an area into a middle class neighbourhood” (Smith and Williams, 1986, p. 1). Gentrification-induced displacement may occur when pressures on the housing market from affluent groups create inflated rents and prices which can push out the low paid or unpaid over time. In a more subtle way, influxes of these groups may alter the social characteristics and services of an area so that residents' social networks are distended while the cost of living may increase as service provision caters for higher income groups.

Here we look at the potential costs that this social upgrading of an area may impose on poorer groups living in those areas. A tendency to see only the positive sides to this process has become a dominant part of the discourse on forecasting how our cities will change and on the desirability of encouraging affluent households to move into central city areas. Given recent moves to assess the prospects for an 'urban renaissance' (Urban Task Force, 1999b) and an emphasis on the possible boon that new 'urban pioneers' may bring, it is perhaps timely that we turn our attention to the unintended consequences that such groups may have on neighbourhood outcomes.

This paper attempts to synthesise past research efforts, to draw on disparate data sources (including census and interview material), and to revitalise the debate with data that provides some evidence of a more understated view of the boon which such pioneers may represent. The connection between gentrification (Glass, 1964) and the displacement of indigenous residents has barely been made in the British and European context (though see Power, 1973; Green, 1979). However, a literature on displacement, predominantly from North America, would suggest that such problems have indeed occurred in gentrified areas.

This paper details background census and Longitudinal Study (LS) data which indicates the broad socio-economic and demographic changes occurring in the study areas before using the accounts of tenant's right's workers and estate agents in the study areas to help describe the wider costs to residents imposed by strong upward socio-economic changes in such areas. The paper concludes with comments about how the costs of gentrification may be ameliorated.

2. Evidence of displacement from North America and Britain

While work has been done on gentrification in general (Smith and Williams, 1986; Van Weesep and Musterd, 1991; Smith, 1995) and its manifestation in London in particular (Hamnett and Williams, 1979; Munt, 1987; Warde, 1991; Bridge, 1993; Butler, 1996), there has been little research conducted in Britain into its ability to displace households. A lack of attention to the issue of displacement may reflect our attachment to the exchange value of houses above that of their use value. In fact, so embedded is the logic of property relations in everyday life, that Blomley has described these relations in terms of their ontological status (Blomley, 1997).

Perhaps the main reason that displacement research has not been replicated in the European context lies in the methodological problems associated with such work. This empirical gap has often been attributed to the complexity of tracking those displaced (Hamnett and Williams, 1979). As

has been noted (LeGates and Hartman, 1986; Cohen and Mowbray, 1993) tracking people over space, such as the street homeless and displacees, is highly difficult. Further, the connection of housing with wider social processes makes it difficult to discern the causal mechanism by which displacement is instigated (Badcock and Cloher, 1979).

Given the virtual impossibility of finding a sample of displacees to interview, the research turned to the accounts of Tenant's Rights Workers of Central London. An advert was placed in the 'Big Issue' magazine which homeless people sell. This yielded two responses, both of which were unsuitable. Because of these problems, three tenant's rights projects were selected, which were located in areas identified using census data, to look at areas which had rapidly been gentrified during the 1981 to 1991 period. This was done using the proxy measure of increases in the resident professional and managerial population. To get a fuller impression of the changes in the areas studied, 'lifestyle' and property supplements were regularly read and the gentrified areas were visited to validate their choice as places suitable for examining the process of displacement in closer detail.

It is difficult to judge which factors, such as a lack of money, job loss, or landlord harassment, are fundamental in understanding displacement processes. It is likely that in individual cases the reasons may be complex. However, it may be possible to observe a relationship between neighbourhood change in the form of professionalisation and the exiting of various groups from that area by those with fewer resources. Structures of rent and sale values may create a strong pressure to leave and an exclusion, or diversion, from access to a neighbourhood.

Displacement is marked out by its near invisibility; where it has happened no indicators remain. However, various data sources have been used to estimate its size. Looking at twelve neighbourhoods undergoing revitalisation in six cities in North America, DeGiovanni (1984) used tenure conversion, from renting to owning, as an indicator for displacement. However, it was acknowledged that this was "a rough indicator of only one source of displacement", though likely to produce an underestimate. In a comprehensive survey of the literature, Hartman (1979a) documented the destination and living circumstances of displacees moving to more expensive and overcrowded accommodation, with more than 80% having to pay more for worse accommodation.

Writers like Lee and Hodge (1984) distinguish between liberal and conservative definitions of displacement. They have shown how such ideologies affect our perception of the magnitude of the process. From a conservative perspective, only more extreme forms of harassment and eviction are considered to be a displacement pressure. To the more liberal mind, displace-

ment is a process that might include the pricing out of residents and the changing of shops and services. Complicating things further, it may be that groups labelled as displacees by social scientists may not class themselves as such. Rent increases may seem inevitable and displacees may be fatalistic about the way that the market operates. As Harvey (1967) comments: "What tenants have to suffer at the hands of private landlords has always been treated as a private matter with which they are expected to deal on their own and as best they can, no matter what their age or capabilities" (p. 11).

In other research, Sumka (1979) considered that of the two million people being annually displaced in the US, 86% of the moves were due to 'market' displacement from gentrification and that the displacees were mostly urban white working-class households. This figure was strongly contested as an under-estimate by Hartman (1979a). Further figures are available from Hartman (1979b), who described how the District of Columbia Rental Accommodations Office estimated that a 'mind-boggling' seventh of the entire city's population would be displaced over the next four years from gentrification activity. Marcuse (1986) has estimated that 150,000 people were displaced annually from abandonment and 38,000 from gentrification in New York.

Writers such as O'Malley (1977) have documented that street clearance and urban improvement alone in nineteenth century London evicted 100,000 people from Central London between 1830 and 1880 (O'Malley, 1977, p. 10). More recently, Jew (1994) reported that annually 9% of tenants (144,000 people) would be illegally evicted or harassed from their homes. The 1986/87 London Housing Survey (see LPAC, 1990, p. 21) estimated that 17,000 dwellings were lost annually from private renting in the mid-1980s. In interviews, recent owner-occupiers in those properties were asked who they had bought their property from. Of these, it was estimated that 3,000 were existing tenants, while three times as many (12,000) had bought from developers or builders, indicating a high rate of population turnover on the conversion of tenure.

In a study, sponsored by the then Department of the Environment, carried out in twelve inner London boroughs, a survey was used to find out what was happening to people living in housing rehabilitated using a grant disbursed by local authorities (McCarthy, 1974). Grant-aided improvements did not benefit the original residents, with 68% of applications being preceded by households leaving the accommodation. The main reason for such moves was landlord harassment (43%), and McCarthy described the process as a 'social sieve'.

Leckie (1995) has estimated that 144,000 people are forcefully evicted each year in Britain. He estimates that a further 60,000 or more will be evicted per year in the future, though clearly only a small proportion of

this figure might relate to gentrification-induced displacement. In an OPCS-commissioned study (Pickering and Rauta, 1992), the figure of 1 in 10 tenants being harassed each year was given (based on a question which asked if the tenant had been made in any way uncomfortable by their landlord). In addition, 2% of all tenants in the survey had experienced landlords who had tried to evict them in 'other ways'. In the 1996/7 Survey of English Housing, 11% of renters in London had moved to their current location because their landlord told them to move out.

More recent work by Lyons (1996) finds that local migration is associated with low-status households, while longer range migration may be associated with those of higher status, indicating a greater degree of choice for such movers. This research suggests that displacee moves are predominantly made to locations nearby but to property which is in a worse condition. They often move to a friend or relative's accommodation, which may help to account for much of the subsequent overcrowding experienced by displacees and the increased amount of hidden household formation.

3. Gentrification and displacement in London, 1981–1991

Here we detail the selection of the areas studied, along with background census and LS data which demonstrates the existence of possible displacement effects in areas that were gentrified. It is interesting to look at the background statistical data for the area of inner London and the three local authority or borough areas within which the tenant's rights projects were located. Taking three simple and separable measures of gentrification – namely increases in the numbers of professionally employed and managerial workers, degree holders, and owner-occupiers – we see the following increases for inner London in Table 1.

From the review of the displacement literature, the following groups were selected: working class, private renters, elderly (65 plus), and unskilled workers. For inner London, the mean percentage point changes in wards over the period can be seen in the first column of Table 1, while the other columns indicate the percentage point change for each of the boroughs in which qualitative work was engaged in.

While we do not know if the people in 1991 in these areas were the same as those in 1981, the negative changes for the displacee categories would indicate that processes of replacement or displacement had been occurring, though we can only speculate on the relative proportions of such flows. In the case study boroughs – Hammersmith, Kensington, and Camden – Table 1 shows some degree of variability in the experience of the average changes in the 1981–1991 period. The centrality of these areas in the city core of

Table 1. Percentage point changes for gentrifier and potential displacee groups between 1981 and 1991

	Inner London	Kensington	Camden	Hammersmith
Gentrifiers				
Owner-occupiers	11.2	8.1	9.8	12.2
Professionals	8.3	9.3	7.4	11.6
Degree holders	7.4	8.6	8.4	10.4
Displacees				
Working class	-13.9	-14.6	-12.7	-15.3
Private renters	-4.9	-8.0	-7.0	-8.9
Elderly	-2.3	-1.1	-2.4	-3.8
Unskilled	-1.84	-0.2	-1.1	-2.6

Source: OPCS, 1981 and 1991 Censuses.

Table 2. Household tenure in the study areas

	Residents in households (%)						Professional residents	
	Owner-occupied		Private rented*		Local authority**		(over 16 years)	
	1981	1991	1981	1991	1981	1991	1981	1991
Inner London	29.8	43.9	23.4	20.6	46.7	35.3	24.6	32
Camden	25.9	37.8	31.6	23.9	38.1	38.1	35.1	42.6
Hammersmith	33.9	48	34.5	24.6	31.5	27.2	28.4	40
Kensington	37.4	47.7	45.9	35.6	16.5	16.5	38.9	48.2

Source: OPCS, 1981 and 1991 Census data.

* Not including renting from a business.

** Not including housing association dwellings.

Greater London makes them of theoretical interest, since we might suppose that changes in this area would be more dramatic than for London as a whole. What we see in these areas is pronounced losses of working class groups and private renters. There is a relatively similar level of increases in the three gentrification proxy variables, which might indicate some overlap in these categories.

Table 2 provides background data illustrating the professional and tenurial structure of the inner area of London and the case study authority areas. This table illustrates the continuing and relatively unusual tenure structure of London compared to the rest of Britain. It shows a stronger rental sector than many other areas but a greater decline in this tenure than for local authority dwellings. We can also see that the relatively significant social changes were accompanied by similarly significant tenurial changes. The growth in owner-

Table 3. Net flows and percentage gain or loss for gentrified areas in Greater London between 1981 and 1991

Displacee group	(1) Net migration for gentrified areas	(2) Percentage loss to gentrified areas	(3) Total migration flow for London
Unskilled	–1,800	–78%	19,100
Inactive	–26,100	–46%	38,500
Working class	–19,300	–38%	121,700
Elderly	–23,200	–18%	20,000

Source: ONS Longitudinal Study.

occupation, only partly explained by right to buy sales, greatly exceeded both the rest of London and national trends over the same period. The dramatic growth of owner-occupation is predominantly explained by the loss of rental accommodation. We can see an attendant increase in professional residents associated with the growth in owner-occupation.

Atkinson (2000a) shows that losses for potential displacee groups in gentrified wards were far greater than in wards in the rest of the metropolitan area. Table 3 uses that data to show changes over the decade in wards gentrified (measured as above-average increases in the numbers of professionals over the period in any ward). The first column shows the net change for areas which experienced above-average levels of professionalisation. Column 2 shows the percentage loss to the social group over the decade and column 3 indicates the amount of movement in the rest of the London area for the same period.

The gentrified areas covered approximately a sixteenth of the London area. Yet for many of the potential displacee groups, we see a rate of out-migration in the gentrified areas almost equal to that of London as a whole. For example, we see that the numbers of elderly leaving the gentrified areas (23,200) were actually greater than that for moves made by that group in the capital as a whole (20,000). Even if one were to suppose that migration based on retirement was a factor, this could not be used to explain the extent of the process in areas which had been gentrified. These results suggest that displacement as well as replacement was an active process over the period.

4. Neighbourhood change and displacement in central London

This section presents the results of interviews with a range of actors in the three central London boroughs. Interviews took place over a three-month

period and involved staff in three of the tenant's rights projects. The remit of these organisations is the protection of private tenant's rights and they were set up to protect tenants from harassment and illegal eviction as well as to provide advice and support regarding entitlement to benefits and help. While such a group may be considered to have a vested interest in portraying gentrification as an anti-social force, the validation of the material here with external data and inter-group confirmation lends weight to the accuracy of the accounts.

The projects were selected because they existed in areas which have been extensively gentrified and deal with a population who are the most likely candidates for displacement, namely private renters. The work of the projects is predicated on the illegal practices of landlords in the area. All of the projects reported a caseload which was stretching their capacities. Most of the work comes from representing victims of eviction who are unable to pay for their defence by solicitors. Thus, referrals to the projects come from citizen's advice bureaux and the local authority, which provided core funding for their work. While small in number, the geographical remit of the projects was wide (i.e. the entire borough), giving access to a comprehensive picture of changes and problems in the area.

The testimonies of the project workers are presented below, along with supporting data. That material should be considered in tandem with the census evidence already developed. There is a danger of conflating data on evictions with data on displacement. We have tried to avoid this wherever possible, but it should be borne in mind that eviction was viewed as an indicator of gentrification in these areas.

Who were the displacees? The elderly were considered to be disproportionately represented among displacees by all of the project workers. The reason for this was twofold. First, physical frailty made it difficult to resist actions by landlords to have them removed. Second, this group was more profoundly affected by social changes around them. The loss of friends or kinship networks was cited as a reason for the decision to move from an area, to move where family have moved or, finally, to find someplace cheaper. These findings are consistent with research carried out by Henig (1984), who found that such groups were least able to cope with the pressures of a gentrified neighbourhood, with its radically altered kin and friendship networks. Involuntary movement from a place called 'home' was likened to grieving (see also Chan, 1986). Perhaps this should not be surprising, as Hartman argues:

displacement means moving from a supportive, long-term environment to an alien area where substantially higher costs are involved for a more crowded, inferior dwelling. (1979b, p. 23)

Table 4. Protection from eviction offences, clear-ups and case results

	Protection from eviction offences		Protection from eviction clear-ups		Persons accused of protection from eviction offences	
	1998/1999	April–Dec 1999	1998/1999	April–Dec 1999	1998/1999	April–Dec 1999
Hammersmith	3	0	2	0	0	0
Camden	1	3	0	0	0	0
Kensington	2	2	0	0	0	0
Total	6	5	2	0	0	0
Metropolitan Police	54	32	9	4	1	1
Service total						

Source: Metropolitan Police Service, Performance Information Bureau.

Many secure tenants are found in this older age range. This often created problems when the landlord was trying to get the rent increased to a market level. Secure tenants are those who rent privately since, or before, the 1977 Protection from Eviction Act was set up. This group is therefore often comprised of older tenants. They have greater protection from rent increases, as all proposed increases in rent can be referred to the Rent Officer. When asked whether there had been harassment of secure tenants in order to get them to sign assured shorthold contracts (mentioned in Burrows and Hunter, 1990), it appeared that harassment had been more often used to get rid of tenants than to persuade them to change the conditions of their tenancy.

Table 4 helps to illustrate the lack of statutory activity that deals with problems of harassment in London as a whole. Here we see a stark contrast between police involvement in eviction action and the story of harassment revealed by the Tenant's Rights workers; no landlord was accused under the 1977 Protection from Eviction Act in any of the case study authorities. This disparity is explained, in part, by a lack of reporting behaviour by victims of eviction, who are often unsure of their rights. Writers such as Burrows and Hunter (1990) have also suggested that the police are often unsure of what to do in eviction cases or may take the side of the landlord. These figures stand in sharp contrast with general levels of eviction. Those levels are now higher than they were in the 1970s, especially in view of the large number of repossessions applied for. For example, in the first quarter of 1996, private landlords nationally entered 29,235 court actions for possession, while mortgage lenders entered 23,993.

Further evidence of these processes comes in the form of Rent Assessment Committees, set up under the Rent Act of 1965 to arbitrate on decisions made by Rent Officers deemed to be unfair by landlords or tenants. Their existence has not been seen to be effective, given that they have consistently favoured landlords in their decisions. In London, nearly 90% of rulings favour the land-

lord. Since deregulation, they have been accused of bias in order to promote the growth of the rented sector by succumbing to landlords' desires to obtain greater revenues. Rental assessments are strongly affected by surrounding locational attributes. If the area has been gentrified and its attendant services have also changed, landlords often used these developments to make the case that the area is now much more desirable and that a greater return is in order. Tenants are often deterred from court challenges because of the cost and because they often fear retaliatory evictions, ironically, if they win the case.

The Home Office Research and Statistics Department indicates that prosecutions under the Protection from Eviction Act (1977) were 84 out of 222 cases in 1993 for the whole of England and Wales. This might be considered a low figure when reports indicate that something like one in 10 tenants faces some form of harassment (Rauta and Pickering, 1992). Fines for such offences are often derisory (75% of fines were under £300 in 1993, Bedsit Briefing, April/May, 1996).

In all of the areas studied, houses in multiple occupation (HMOs) were prevalent. These units are often associated with some of the worst living conditions, yet they provide a relatively affordable form of living. Retention of these units is often viewed by boroughs as being an important issue because of the groups they cater for. However, boroughs differ markedly on discretionary policies toward HMOs. People living in this sector have often been displaced when units have been converted into owner-occupation or where units are combined into bigger dwelling spaces (London Research Centre, 1994).

Many of the case workers in the projects suggested that people with mental health problems suffered if displaced. The policy of care in the community meant that many people needing help had been left to cope in highly competitive housing markets. In particular, people with alcohol problems, HIV, or psychiatric disorders were identified by the project workers as having particular problems in relation to the housing market and have few social services to turn to.

Families on low incomes may also be trapped. Housing benefit will not be paid to them because they receive some income, yet they struggle to keep their head above water in a market where rents stretch their ability to cope to the limit. One project worker said that she had advised very low paid families to give up work in order to get help with the rent. Another project worker summed up the position as affecting:

Single people, or couples without children who wouldn't be eligible to get local authority housing are being displaced even if they are moving into local authority housing. Even if they are on income support or on a very low income the benefit is not enough to cover their rents so the displace-

ment now is people who would have been able to afford property because of benefit levels but now can't – it's the high rents that are displacing people but benefit rule changes are adding to that (Case worker, Tenant's Rights Project, Hammersmith).

The burden of displacement appeared to fall on single people in particular. It is often hard for single people to afford accommodation. This often manifests itself in the high number of flat shares and lodgers in these areas. Two of the project workers suggested that the interaction between benefit changes and rental rates was creating increased vulnerability, since lower benefit levels would mean that a tenant's capacity to resist being 'priced out' was reduced. The introduction of the single room rent, intended for housing benefit claimants who are single and under 25, means that they are tied to the average cost of shared accommodation in the area as determined by the rent officer. This further squeezes the availability of accommodation for such groups. For example, research by Kemp and Rugg (1998) found that in an inner London borough, a typical one-room rent was £65 while the single room rent level was only £45.

Ethnic minority groups were also cited as having suffered substantial displacement in certain areas. Where ethnic minorities lived in areas that had become desirable, project workers described how substantial displacement of the indigenous community, often Afro-Caribbean, Asians, and Irish, had occurred. This is a combination of the historical location of such groups in previously 'filtered' areas and their gentrification more recently. However, we should be guarded in accepting such evidence uncritically, given that census data indicates a propensity for areas being gentrified by professionals and managers to be apparent 'attractors' for such groups (Atkinson, 2000b).

In Kensington, processes of gentrification created a continued upward movement in the status of those being displaced and those acting as gentrifiers. This process was described by one project worker in terms of the 'Sloanes' (upper class young people) of yesteryear being displaced by the stockbrokers of today due to the upward spiral of social change in that area. Just such a phenomenon is alluded to by O'Malley, reporting on work in Kensington in the late 1960s, who described how "higher income tenants who had displaced the low income families were now faced with a [local authority] plan to displace them with even higher income tenants or flat buyers" (1970, p. 104).

This suggests that gentrification is not new in the area. It is echoed by Lyons' (1996) point that gentrified areas experience outflows by successively higher status households. Such processes have also been confirmed by Dangschat (1991) in his continuum of gentrification waves from 'pioneer' to

'ultra' gentrifiers in Hamburg. In general, the characterisation of displacees given by the project workers was one of vulnerability; through physical or mental frailty, a lack of social and financial resources, and faced with a lack of affordable housing.

5. How does displacement occur?

We have noted that displacement was most often achieved through rental and price increases, though other, more insidious, methods were also used by landlords. Tenants were sometimes encouraged to move out through inducements (cash sums for vacating the premises), harassment, violence and intimidation, while eviction and rent rises also led to displacement. One Kensington project worker described how a large number of prosecutions 'disappeared' because landlords offered often large sums of money to move away, as she put it "if you're poor enough you are going to take it". Many tenants being 'bought out' were elderly; according to an internal report from Camden, 33% of elderly regulated tenants were facing harassment or inducements to leave. An explicit link was made between gentrification and being made homeless. As one project worker suggested, "gentrification is what is making people homeless. If you are going to move a certain person into the area the only way you are going to do that is by moving someone else out." (Case worker, Tenant's Rights Project, Kensington).

For many landlords, there is no longer any need for harassment or eviction because of the landlord's ability to terminate assured shorthold tenancy agreements after the initial six-month period. However, harassment was prevalent for elderly tenants, often because it was this group that had protected tenancies. While threats often lay behind the offer of payments to leave, more direct action by landlords was not rare in the effort to get rid of unwanted tenants as a means to get better-paying tenants or to sell. The process was described in the following terms:

some of the people who were got out were evicted; they were got out by fairly unpleasant and in most cases illegal methods. There were a lot of people displaced from that period [late eighties]. More recently it has been more an income-related thing, it's been "we don't need to resort to illegal methods all we do is basically keep upping the rent" until they can't afford it. (Case worker, Tenant's Rights Project, Kensington)

Where violence and threats had been used, stronger legal remedies were available to prevent harassment than where rent increases occurred. Softer forms of displacement, such as price increases, are often not viewed as displacement. They are largely seen as acceptable or tolerable forms of exclusion

in the wider community. Indeed, they appeal to a market logic of property relations to which many subscribe (Blomley, 1997).

Exclusion from the case study areas has become a theme for commentators on London's housing market. This issue is reflected in recent policy concerns about the ability of essential service workers, like teachers, to live in the area they work in. Many people are diverted from entry to locations or unable to re-enter areas after being dislodged from more affordable accommodation. The children of parents in council or other protected forms of tenancy were often unable to stay in the same area after moving away from home because of high local prices and rents. Welfare benefit increasingly does not cover rents, and property agents are often not interested in those on state benefits.

In one notable case, displacement was induced to achieve greater charitable returns for a trust. The estate, gentrified to maximise rental and sales returns, was used for charitable purposes; "charitable purposes paid for by driving people off the estate" (Project worker, Case 1). In another example, a religious charitable body was linked to the displacement of tenants in order to maximise rental returns. On the Kings Road, they evicted artists from dwellings in order to sell the property. There have been other examples whereby charities have had their tenancies left un-renewed so that higher-paying tenants could enter.

It is not only in the private sector that such oddities may occur. An examination of the previous status of properties on short-term leases to housing associations and local authorities for use as temporary accommodation revealed that:

there was concern that the development of such schemes – whose prime purpose was to house homeless people – could be directly causing homelessness by giving landlords a (financial) incentive to evict existing tenants whose rents were controlled. (London Research Centre, 1990, p. 25)

Displacement research has often suffered from a lack of information about where people end up. In asking the project workers about this, there was some consensus on a number of exit routes. There was widespread recognition that a significant number of displacees were made homeless. However, the main exit route was to buy or continue renting. Inevitably, this meant that displacees would be forced to move out of the area, since it would be too expensive to remain. For some, it was a case of wherever was cheapest, often renting with others or going to family and friends if they lived in London. For the elderly, the subsequent location was often to areas beyond London:

the traditional thing – of moving to the seaside or to the country. Some of them, yes, outer ring [of London], as far as poorer displacees go I am more concerned about them, I suspect some of them end up on the street,

literally. There are two issues, if they were pre-1989 renters they won't have a deposit and even if they do the levels of rents are terrifying. (Case worker, Tenant's Rights Project, Hammersmith)

The implications of neighbourhood-wide changes may influence such decisions. In Camden, benefit data showed that the number of claimants in hotels was 600 less between January 1996 and December 1997. This was attributed to a number of factors, including a growth in tourism. As for future rates, it was envisaged that the reduction in the availability of bed and breakfast accommodation and the loss of HMOs would increase levels of displacement, as fewer places are available at affordable rates. Guidance to prospective residents on the Borough of Camden's website advises that:

Unless you have a great deal of money finding a place to live in London is going to be difficult. Obtaining social housing is not an option for the majority of people. Camden is one of the most expensive and desirable areas of London. There is a great deal of competition for all types of accommodation. Landlords can choose their tenants from a pool of high earning professionals . . . If you are to succeed in finding accommodation you will have to look beyond Camden and beyond Central London in areas where prices are cheaper and the competition for private flats is not so great.

6. The wider effects of gentrification

Contradictory evidence on the effect of gentrification on social networks exists. While the project workers saw widespread problems, Bridge (1993) has argued that the impact of gentrification on friendship networks in Sands End, Hammersmith was minimal. However, such an analysis is only possible where gentrification is not total or extensive. The impact of middle-class residents can also have a perverse effect on areas where:

What is actually provided is poorer because obviously the richer the community becomes the less necessary it is to have public transport, the less necessary it is to have facilities like good libraries, leisure facilities that are subsidised by a local authority, the less pressure there is on the local authority to provide services. (Case worker, Tenant's Rights Project, Kensington)

This contradiction was especially apparent in both Camden and Kensington. There, the need for various public services was eroded by changes in consumption patterns in reaction to changes in the profile of local residents. This also acts as a self-serving legitimisation for the loss of such public services, since the local authority argued that such services were not needed.

In an apparent mirroring of the process of abandonment and low demand in poor neighbourhoods, it was observed by all of the project workers that, for many residents, gentrification cumulatively eroded both their ability and their desire to remain in that location as social, physical, economic, and environmental changes took place unrelated to the patterns of their own lifestyles and the resources on which they lived. In Kensington:

people are being offered money they can't refuse, and they are also probably moving out because as the gentrification snowball rolls down the hill so it becomes less desirable for them to stay there, it's no longer their sort of people . . . There has also been the development of hundreds of poor quality hotels, part of that has been created by the need for homeless persons accommodation and most of them double as brothels. (Case worker, Tenant's Rights Project, Kensington)

Increasing crime levels were related by the project workers to the breakdown of close-knit communities from the impact of the turnover of residents. This seemed to be most strongly felt in South Kensington and could be related to absent owners in that area. Certainly empty property and the transitory nature of many residents left little social fabric, which was then associated with increases in crime and anti-social behaviour. A crack-cocaine problem and related street crime, already visible in the north of the borough, were making an unwelcome entrance to the area.

A trend identified in both Camden and Hammersmith was the increasing number of people from multiple-occupied properties who had mental health problems. While hospital closures and care in the community played a part, there was obviously more going on:

so many people that you met in multi-occupied properties, pretty much left on their own . . . not having to conform an awful lot; lots of those people have mental health problems – that accommodation doesn't exist anymore, so they are the kind of people who are driven out. Where do those people go? (Case worker, Tenant's Rights Project, Hammersmith)

Shops and services were also affected. A new service infrastructure had sprung up around the wealthy new residents. Bars replaced pubs and delicatessens replaced grocers, increasing the cost of living or distending the scope of shopping trips. Such changes are often perceived as improving an area, yet they belie the reality that social problems have not been resolved. Instead, problem people have been moved on. The sense of separation from the boom going on around them meant that many remaining tenants expressed attitudes of resentment (see also: Rotherhithe Community Planning Centre, 1986) and racism toward wealthy British in-migrants and those from overseas. In the East End of London, similar sentiments toward lower-status

in-migrants were redirected by the ‘mug a yuppie’ campaign of Class War, an extreme political left-wing group, as a transferral of racist aggression (Wright, 1992).

Other groups, like the ‘Roughlers’, a now defunct gathering of drinkers and self-proclaimed yuppie-haters on the Portobello Road in Kensington, indicate that the visible signs of a front-line have been replaced by a more insidious geography of privilege and antipathy that is more difficult to locate. The landlord of the pub where the Roughlers met described how they ‘retreated’ from pub to pub as the area grew ever more popular with yuppies who ‘took over’ the pubs.

Interviews with estate agents in north Kensington showed that the cultural infrastructure of the area and the proximity of the underground tube line were critical factors in location decisions by City workers who had moved to the area en masse. One property agent described the changes in the neighbourhood as “economic migration as it should be”. Of the ten agents contacted, seven described the social change in the area in terms of negative consequences for poorly paid and unpaid residents, even though it provided a boom for their business. The embeddedness of owner-occupation as a discourse which privileges ownership over other forms is critical here, as Smith cited: ‘What I want to know,’ argued one recent immigrant to the neighbourhood, ‘is by what authority do these people have roots? If you don’t own, you don’t have roots. What have they planted, their feet in the ground?’ (Smith, 1996, p. 138).

As gentrification proceeds, levels of resistance to it are cumulatively lessened. Perceived levels of need were lowered, while the distance of needy residents to services set up by local authority and voluntary groups was increased. In Hammersmith, it was argued that “if the poor disappear the rationale for the group’s existence similarly disappears” (Case worker, Tenant’s Rights Project, Hammersmith). These problems also weakened:

people’s involvement in local government, people’s interest in community issues, it therefore has a knock on effect on voluntary groups, with some of the community organisations that are based in the borough – and as those weaken so the people being displaced have fewer places to go to try and resist being displaced, it’s a snowball; I can’t see any way it’s going to stop unless we stop spiralling rents and house prices. (Case worker A, Tenant’s Rights Project, Camden)

Middle-class groupings were viewed as being closer to the local political process and knew how to ‘work’ it better than lower-class groupings. Political change was both complementary to the gentrification process and was also influenced by gentrifiers. In addition to local authorities, other groups, like the Hampstead Heath Society and the Camden Amenities Forum, were

considered to be very influential in development control. As a Camden project worker pointed out, “in Camden you’ve got council estates falling behind, private sector harassment at record levels and yet people take the council to court over their parking restrictions” (Case worker B, Tenant’s Rights Project, Hammersmith).

The reasons for this lie partly in the degree of articulation of affluent groups. But they also arise because the council has less autonomy over such groups. With self-funded groups, like the Hampstead Heath Society, there is a relatively high level of independence so that political marginalisation is made more difficult. This echoes Hartman’s comment that “It is not clear that the ‘new urbanites’ will provide so great a boon for fiscal solvency; their demands for – and ability to extract from city government – urban services and amenities may offset any additional property tax revenues” (1979b, p. 26).

The role of the local authority and a political will in general to stand back or become involved is critical in the way that gentrification proceeds. O’Malley describes how the then stockbroker chief executive, in 1968, prophesied the changes to come: “Kensington is bound to become a middle class community . . . the lower income people are bound to be excluded” (1977, p. 19). More recently, Hamnett and Randolph comment that “affordable private renting in central London today is no longer a possible option. Those who cannot buy here have in effect been displaced to alternative locations beyond the centre . . . or to alternative tenures” (Hamnett and Randolph, 1984, p. 276).

However, we should question the inevitability or a portrayed ‘natural’ quality of such changes as the ideology of a *laissez-faire* stance on neighbourhood change. Policy resolutions have been made to prevent the damaging effects of gentrification. Preventing the quick purchase and resale of property is one remedy. In the late 1970s, in Santa Cruz, California, voters passed an initiative imposing heavy taxes on the vendor of dwellings sold within four years. The levy was imposed on a sliding scale inversely related to the number of years the property was held prior to sale (Hartman, 1979b) ranging from 18% to 25%.

Such proposals may not be unrealistic, given that a similar ‘sunshine tax’ was recently proposed in Cornwall, South West England, due to continuing retirement to the area by wealthy migrants. Perhaps discretionary control of such policies is unlikely to be successful, given famous examples of authorities like Westminster, which have pursued gentrification as a means of securing political survival and to boost local revenue. Leckie (1995) has suggested that formal arbitration schemes for those forcefully evicted should

be set up. The assessments for compensation would be based on the cost to the displacee of relocation and travel costs after displacement.

7. Conclusions

Gentrification has been construed as both destroyer and saviour in the regeneration of run-down areas, yet it is clear that it is not simply one or the other. There are both positive and negative aspects to gentrification. Its effects are mediated to vulnerable social groups by socio-legal (Leckie, 1995), welfare (Hamnett, 1996), and local democratic processes (Bourne, 1993) found in the fieldwork reported here and varying widely due to context and the political affiliation of observers. As Bourne argues, gentrification:

has improved housing quality and social service levels, altered the political dynamic and augmented the local tax base of the central city (in part through a redistribution of investment) [but] it has contributed to a reduction in the low-rent housing stock and displaced hundreds of residents, some of whom (notably tenants) have suffered as a consequence. (Bourne, 1993, p. 185)

In some respects, public housing estates share burdens similar to those borne by poorer groups in gentrified areas. In attempting to ameliorate such burdens, we should be aware that neighbourhood change is constant, though its direction is a malleable outcome which can be and is being shaped by policy interventions. Research on tenure diversification indicates that gradual social movements are much less damaging and may bring positive social changes to run-down and public-rented areas (Atkinson and Kintrea, 1998). Where diversity and interconnections do exist, such initiatives have been seen to be positive (Jupp, 1999).

The re-emergence of central London as a middle-class city as it was in the late nineteenth century does not represent the kind of diversity or affordability that will ensure the sustainability either of that area or the surrounding neighbourhoods, which act as buffers for those excluded from central city property markets. While gentrification may often be based on the replacement of indigenous communities during 'natural' turnover, such changes are further reaching and may also be based on displacement. Recent discontent over the lack of momentum in Lord Roger's Urban Taskforce by the Government suggests a need to continue to consider the health and diversity of communities in areas like London.

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